

ANGEL ACTION · ENVIRONMENTAL

Drowning

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What to do

1. **Call 000** for every drowning casualty.
2. Remove them from the water — **do not endanger yourself**. Throw a rope or flotation device if you cannot safely enter the water.
3. Follow **DRSABCD**.
4. Lay them on their back. If they are not breathing normally, start **CPR** immediately — give **5 initial rescue breaths** before starting compressions.
5. Be prepared for vomiting — roll on their side and clear the mouth.
6. Continue CPR until they recover or paramedics arrive.
7. Do **not** try to empty water from the stomach by pressing on the abdomen.

Secondary drowning

Anyone who has nearly drowned should be assessed at hospital, even if they seem fine. Water in the lungs can cause life-threatening problems hours later.

Hypothermia

People rescued from cold water are often hypothermic — see **hypothermia**. Continue CPR for longer than usual; resuscitation has succeeded after extended periods in cold water.

*Adapted from **Australian First Aid 5th Edition**. Get the full guide and live CPR metronome at firstaidangel.org.*